

Damara Cohn

DELRAY BEACH · BOCA RATON · THE COASTAL CORRIDOR

The Coastal Insider Guide

A short, practical guide to buying and relocating along the Delray Beach to Boca Raton coast — flood zones, closing costs, the homestead exemption, and the six-step checklist to run before you move.

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A NOTE FROM DAMARA



Before you read any further —

I've sold real estate on this stretch of coast for more than 25 years — Delray Beach, Boca Raton, and every small town in between. In that time I've watched two market crashes, one full rebuild, and thousands of people move here from somewhere else entirely.

This guide is the version of "what you actually need to know" I'd tell you if we were sitting across from each other, not a generic checklist pulled from a national franchise site. It covers the real, practical questions relocating buyers ask me most: flood zones and what they actually cost, what closing really involves here, how the homestead exemption works, and the six things I tell every client to check before they move.

A few of the numbers in here — insurance premiums, closing cost percentages, exemption amounts — are general Florida and Palm Beach County figures, current as of 2026. They're a real starting point, not a quote for your specific property. I'll always run the actual numbers with you directly before you make any decision.

One more thing, since it matters to how I work: I run a boutique brokerage, not a large national franchise. That means the person you talk to on day one is the same person overseeing your transaction on day sixty — my personal attention, my 25+ years of local expertise, not a rotating cast of assistants. If something in here raises a question, just ask me directly.

Damara

BROKER-OWNER, MANGROVE REALTY

THE TERRITORY

The Corridor at a Glance

Six towns, six very different markets, all stacked along about 12 miles of coastline in southern Palm Beach County. Here's where everything sits relative to everything else, and how to get anywhere else from here.



Getting Around

I-95 runs through all six towns; Florida's Turnpike is a short drive inland from any of them. Delray Beach sits roughly in the middle of the corridor, within about 15–20 minutes of every other town on this map.

I-95 through all 6 towns

PBI: ~20–25 min north

FLL: ~30–40 min south

Miami: ~60–75 min south

Boynton Beach · Ocean Ridge · Gulf Stream

The honest version of each town — not marketing copy, just what actually distinguishes one from the next.

Boynton Beach **MOST ACCESSIBLE**

Downtown & Culture: Renaissance Commons and the Town Center area anchor newer mixed-use development, and the "500 Ocean" project has brought fresh energy to the waterfront core near the marina.

Beach Access: Oceanfront Park gives Boynton its own genuine stretch of public beach — a fact a lot of buyers don't realize until they look.

Country Clubs: Hunters Run Country Club, a large private gated golf community, along with several smaller clubs through the city's western neighborhoods.

55+ Communities: Leisureville and Sterling Village — two long-established active-adult communities offering some of the most affordable age-restricted living in the corridor.

Parks & Amenities: Oceanfront Park (beach, playground, amphitheater) and the Boynton Harbor Marina round out the city's public amenities.

Ocean Ridge **QUIET & BUILT-OUT**

Downtown & Culture: None by design — a small, mostly built-out barrier-island town (roughly 63% water) with no commercial or industrial zoning permitted.

Beach Access: A handful of public access points along A1A, but no dedicated beach park — this is a quiet residential town, not a beach-day destination.

Country Clubs & 55+ Communities: None within town limits; residents typically hold memberships in neighboring Delray Beach or Gulf Stream, and this isn't an age-restricted market.

Parks & Amenities: Limited by design. Incorporated in 1931 as the "Town of Boynton Beach," renamed in 1939 to avoid mail confusion with Daytona Beach. Limited turnover and new construction mean inventory here moves in fits and starts.

Gulf Stream **SMALLEST & MOST PRESTIGIOUS**

Downtown & Culture: None — a century-long prohibition on commercial and industrial development means no retail strip at all; Atlantic Avenue in Delray Beach is a five-minute drive.

Beach Access: Overwhelmingly private oceanfront estates; there's no dedicated public beach within town limits.

Country Clubs: Home to Gulf Stream Golf Club, one of the oldest and most storied private clubs in Florida, dating to the 1920s.

55+ Communities & Parks: None — this isn't an age-restricted market, and public amenities are minimal by design. Privacy and understatement define the town far more than visible amenities do. Homes start in the low millions in Place au Soleil and climb into eight figures oceanfront and on the Intracoastal, with thin inventory of only a few hundred homes total.

Delray Beach · Highland Beach · Boca Raton

Continuing south along the coast — the same honest, no-filter version of what each town actually offers.

Delray Beach

WALKABLE DOWNTOWN

Downtown & Culture: Atlantic Avenue anchors a nationally recognized, genuinely walkable downtown of restaurants and galleries, with the Pineapple Grove Arts District just north and the Old School Square cultural campus at its center.

Beach Access: A rarity on this stretch — Delray's public beach runs the length of A1A with metered public parking, open to residents and visitors alike, no permit required.

Country Clubs: Delaire Country Club, a gated golf community west of downtown, plus several other private clubs through the surrounding neighborhoods.

55+ Communities: Kings Point and High Point of Delray, both well west of downtown, offer age-restricted, resort-style living at a lower price point than the coast itself.

Parks & Amenities: Veterans Park sits directly on the Intracoastal downtown and hosts the Saturday GreenMarket; Old School Square anchors arts and events in the historic district. Neighborhoods like Lake Ida and Tropic Isle add quieter, larger-lot living minutes from downtown.

Highland Beach

PRIVATE & QUIET

Downtown & Culture: None — 1.29 square miles with essentially no commercial zoning and not a single traffic light. Dining and shopping mean a short drive into Delray Beach or Boca Raton.

Beach Access: Historically resident-and-guest-only. That's changing: Palm Beach County is building the town's first public oceanfront park, with a boardwalk, snorkeling access, and about 100 parking spaces — decades in the making after prior litigation delayed it.

Country Clubs & 55+ Communities: No golf clubs or age-restricted communities within town limits; residents typically hold memberships in neighboring Delray Beach or Boca Raton. Oceanfront and Intracoastal condo buildings dominate the housing stock, with a large share held as part-time and seasonal residences.

Parks & Amenities: Small and residential by design; the new county park will be the town's first true public amenity. No public schools of its own — properties zone into Delray Beach or Boca Raton's school boundaries depending on the exact address.

Boca Raton

COUNTRY CLUBS & SPACE

Downtown & Culture: Boca's Mizner-era downtown around Mizner Park anchors the east side — shops, restaurants, an outdoor amphitheater, and its own Brightline station.

Beach Access: Three gated public beach parks — South Beach Park, Red Reef Park, and Spanish River Park — each requiring an annual permit or daily fee through the Greater Boca Raton Beach & Park District.

Country Clubs: An unusually dense concentration of gated, membership-based clubs — Royal Palm Yacht & Country Club, St. Andrews, and Boca West among them — each carrying separate club dues on top of HOA costs.

55+ Communities: Century Village at Boca Raton, one of the largest age-restricted communities in the region, sits in West Boca with its own clubhouse and transportation.

Parks & Amenities: Sugar Sand Park, Gumbo Limbo Nature Center, and Mizner Park's own green space — East Boca leans waterfront and walkable, West Boca trades beach proximity for larger lots.

The Relocation Questions Everyone Actually Asks

"How much is flood insurance actually going to cost me?"

It depends entirely on which FEMA flood zone the property sits in — and that can vary block to block, not just town to town. **Zone X** (minimal-risk, most inland and higher-ground properties) doesn't require flood insurance for a federally-backed mortgage, though it's still worth carrying. **Zone AE** (the 1%-annual-chance floodplain, common closer to the Intracoastal) does require it if you're financing. **Zone VE** (direct coastal, wave-action risk) is the highest-cost tier and also mandatory when financed. Get the flood zone and an actual insurance quote before you fall in love with a property, not after.

Zone X: ~\$400–\$800/yr

Zone AE: ~\$1,500–\$3,500/yr

Zone VE: ~\$4,000–\$10,000+/yr

"Should hurricane season scare me off buying here?"

No — but it should inform how you buy, not whether you buy. Every property in this corridor has some level of storm exposure; the honest approach is preparation, not avoidance. Before you close, ask about the roof's age and wind rating, whether the building (if a condo) has completed its post-Surfside milestone inspection and Structural Integrity Reserve Study, and what the insurance history looks like — any non-renewals in the past three years are worth knowing about upfront. People who live here full-time treat June through November as a season to plan around, the same way northern buyers plan around snow.

"What about condo and HOA fees?"

They vary enormously by building age, amenities, and reserve funding — and it's genuinely the single biggest variable in what a condo actually costs to own here, more than the purchase price itself. The short version: ask for the condo docs, the most recent reserve study, and the building's insurance history before you write an offer, every time, no exceptions. I walk every buyer through exactly what to look for — it's worth five minutes on the phone before you fall for a view.

The Six-Step Checklist

Run through these before closing on anything in this corridor — buyer or seller, relocating from out of state or moving three towns over.

1

Confirm the flood zone — for this exact address

Flood zones can change block to block along this coast. Confirm it directly (FEMA's flood map service or your insurance agent), not from a listing description, and get a real quote before you're under contract.

2

Read the HOA/condo docs — all of them

Reserve funding percentage, any pending or recent special assessments, rental restrictions, and pet rules. For condos, ask specifically about the building's post-Surfside milestone inspection and Structural Integrity Reserve Study status.

3

File for the homestead exemption — by March 1

If this will be your permanent Florida residence, the homestead exemption reduces your taxable assessed value (\$25,000 on the first \$50,000 of value, plus an additional exemption on value above that, adjusted annually) and caps future assessment increases at 3% or the CPI change, whichever is lower, under Florida's Save Our Homes law. It does not transfer automatically if you move — a new application is required each time, and the deadline is March 1 of the year you're claiming it. Confirm the exact current figures with the county property appraiser.

4

Understand who pays what at closing

In Palm Beach County, buyers typically pay for the owner's title insurance policy and settlement fees (roughly 2%–5% of the purchase price all-in); sellers typically pay the documentary stamp tax on the deed (\$0.70 per \$100 of sale price) plus their agent's commission. Everything here is technically negotiable in the contract — but knowing the local default before you negotiate is the whole point.

5

Put a hurricane plan in writing — before June

Know your evacuation zone (it's different from your flood zone), have a plan for shutters or impact windows, and review your insurance coverage every year before hurricane season starts, not after a storm is already named.

6

See it in person before you commit

Photos and virtual tours can't tell you what a street sounds like at 7pm, how close a building really is to the water, or how a condo's common areas actually feel. If you're relocating from out of state, I'll walk you through exactly what to schedule in a single trip so it isn't wasted.

IN THEIR WORDS

"Damara was extremely helpful in answering my questions about relocating to Florida. She is extremely knowledgeable and passionate about her work as a realtor. I would highly recommend her services."

— JENNIE BORRELLI, GOOGLE REVIEW

LET'S TALK

Honest answers. Genuine care. 25+ years of experience.

I run a boutique brokerage, not a large national franchise — which means you get my direct oversight, attention, and expertise, not a hand-off to someone you've never spoken to.

I know a move like this can be exciting and a little nerve-wracking, sometimes both in the same phone call. Whatever question is on your mind, ask me directly — I'll give you the same honest, caring answer I'd give a friend.

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Mangrove Realty, Inc. · Licensed Real Estate Brokerage

Damara Cohn, Broker-Owner, Mangrove Realty · Delray Beach, FL · This guide is for general informational purposes only and reflects Florida and Palm Beach County norms as of 2026. Flood insurance premiums, closing costs, and exemption amounts vary by property and change over time — confirm current figures with your insurance agent, closing attorney, and the county property appraiser before making a decision. Not tax or legal advice.